

50 questions d'entretien FIC - FR / EN

À lire avant chaque entretien. Du plus simple au plus complexe.

Comment lire. Chaque question a : la réponse anglaise (à dire tel quel, anglais simple et pro), le rappel FR (pourquoi c'est vrai), et un focus quand la réponse contient un piège. L'anglais est volontairement simple : on juge la clarté, pas le vocabulaire rare.

Sommaire : Bloc A actions (1-6) · B taux (7-14) · C obligations (15-22) · D dérivés fermes (23-28) · E options (29-38) · F vol (39-42) · G crédit & FX (43-46) · H structuration (47-50) · I ton profil (51-60)

BLOC A - Actions (1-6)

1. What is a stock?

"A share of ownership in a company. You get a claim on its profits, usually through dividends, and you take the risk of losing your capital."

FR : part de propriété. Tu es actionnaire, dernier servi en cas de faillite - d'où le rendement attendu plus élevé.

2. What drives a share price?

"Expected future cash flows, discounted back. So two things move it: the expectations themselves, and the rate you discount them at. That's why equities fall when rates rise, all else equal."

Focus. Cette réponse est parfaite parce qu'elle relie actions et taux dès la question 2. Un candidat qui dit juste « l'offre et la demande » passe pour un débutant.

3. What is a dividend?

"Part of the profit paid out to shareholders. On the ex-dividend date, the share price drops by roughly the dividend amount - no free money."

4. What is market cap?

"Share price times number of shares. It's the market's valuation of the equity, not of the whole company - for that you'd add net debt to get enterprise value."

5. What is an index?

"A basket tracking a market - the S&P 500, the CAC 40. Most are market-cap weighted, so the biggest companies drive most of the move."

6. Long or short - what's the difference?

"Long means I own it and I profit if it goes up. Short means I sold something I borrowed, so I profit if it falls - but my loss is unlimited, because there's no ceiling on a price."

Vocabulaire A : *a share / a stock · a dividend · market cap · enterprise value · to go long / short · unlimited downside*

BLOC B - Taux (7-14)

7. What is discounting?

"Money today is worth more than money tomorrow. At four percent, a hundred euros in one year is worth 96.15 today - because 96.15 invested today gives you a hundred."

FR : en 10 ans, ces 100 EUR ne valent plus que 67,56 EUR. Plus c'est loin, moins ça vaut.

8. Simple vs compound interest?

"Simple pays on the principal only. Compound pays on interest already earned. Over long horizons the difference is huge."

Rappel : règle de 72 -> à 6 %, un capital double en 12 ans (exact : 11,9).

9. What is the yield curve?

"It's the price of time - the rate demanded for each maturity. Normally it slopes up, because lending longer is riskier."

10. What does an inverted curve mean?

"Short rates above long rates. It usually means the market expects the central bank to cut - often because a slowdown is coming. It's one of the most watched recession signals."

11. Steepening or flattening?

"Steepening means the gap between short and long widens. Flattening means it narrows. A bear flattener - short rates rising faster - is typical of a central bank tightening."

Focus. Bull veut dire prix qui montent, donc taux qui baissent. C'est contre-intuitif et c'est exactement pour ça qu'on le demande. Ne l'inverse pas.

12. What is a basis point?

"One hundredth of a percent. We say a bip. On ten million, one bip is a thousand euros a year - never negligible."

13. What did the ECB just do?

"They hiked twenty-five bips, taking the deposit rate to 2.50 percent. The market is pricing roughly a forty percent chance of another hike in December."

! Vérifie ce chiffre le matin même sur Yahoo Finance. Une donnée périmée fait plus de mal que pas de donnée.

14. Nominal vs real rate?

"Real is nominal minus inflation. If I earn three percent while inflation runs at three, I've earned nothing in purchasing power."

Vocabulaire B : *to discount · the yield curve · steepening / flattening · a hike / a cut · a basis point (a bip) · to price in · tightening / easing*

BLOC C - Obligations (15-22)

15. What is a bond?

"A loan in tradable form. I lend a hundred, I receive a coupon every year, and I get the principal back at maturity."

16. * Why do bond prices fall when yields rise?

"Because my old bond becomes less attractive. If I hold a three percent bond and the market now offers four, nobody buys mine at par - I have to drop the price until the buyer gets the equivalent of four percent."

Le chiffre : obligation 5 ans, coupon 3 % -> à 3 % elle vaut 100, à 4 % 95,55, à 5 % 91,34.

Focus. C'est LA question du bloc FIC, celle qui élimine. Elle est parfaite parce que tu expliques le mécanisme au lieu de réciter « c'est inversé ». Donne toujours l'exemple du 3 % contre 4 % - il rend la réponse impossible à confondre avec du par cur.

17. What is duration?

"The sensitivity of a bond's price to rates. A duration of five means: rates up one percent, price down about five percent."

Le chiffre : l'obligation ci-dessus a une duration modifiée de 4,53.

Pour +100 bp, l'approximation donne -4,53 %, le vrai calcul -4,40 %.

18. And convexity?

"It's the gap between that approximation and reality. The price-yield relationship is a curve, not a line - so I gain more when rates fall than I lose when they rise. That asymmetry is convexity, and it's why you pay for it."

Le chiffre : -100 bp -> +4,66 % contre -100 bp -> -4,40 %.

19. What is DV01?

"The P&L for a one basis point move. On ten million with a modified duration of 4.53, that's about 4,530 euros per bip. It's how a rates desk actually measures risk - in euros, not percentages."

Focus. Répondre en euros par bip te fait passer d'étudiant à quelqu'un qui a compris comment un desk parle. Un trader ne dit jamais « ma duration est de 5 », il dit « je suis long 4 500 par bip ».

20. Clean price vs dirty price?

"Dirty includes accrued interest, clean doesn't. Prices are quoted clean, but you settle dirty."

21. What is a repo?

"I sell a bond and agree to buy it back tomorrow slightly more expensive. It's a secured loan - that's how a desk funds itself. If everyone wants that specific bond, it's trading special and I fund cheaper."

22. Why do banks hold government bonds?

"Liquidity and regulation - they're the highest quality collateral, and they count towards liquidity ratios. They're also the funding backbone through repo."

Vocabulaire C : *a coupon · at par · duration · convexity · DV01 · accrued interest · repo · trading special · collateral*

BLOC D - Dérivés fermes (23-28)

23. What is a forward?

"An agreement today to trade at a fixed price later. No cash upfront, everything settles at maturity."

24. * Is the forward a forecast of the future price?

"No. It's the spot adjusted for cost of carry - what it costs to hold the asset until maturity, funding minus what the asset pays you. If gold is 2,000 and rates are four percent, the one-year forward is around 2,082 - not because gold will rise, but because you borrow to hold it."

Focus. Le piège le plus fréquent en entretien FIC. Dire « non » franchement, puis expliquer le portage, te distingue immédiatement. La moitié des candidats répond oui.

25. Forward vs future?

"Same economics. A forward is OTC and bespoke with counterparty risk. A future is exchange-traded, standardised, cleared, and margined daily - so your cash flows are spread over the life of the trade."

26. What is an interest rate swap?

"Two parties exchange interest flows on a notional. One pays fixed, one pays floating. The notional never changes hands - only the interest does."

27. Why would a company enter a swap?

"Say it borrowed floating and fears rates rising. It pays fixed and receives floating, so it has effectively turned floating debt into fixed debt. It bought certainty."

28. Paying fixed - am I long or short duration?

"Short duration. I profit when rates rise. Paying fixed is economically like being short a bond."

Focus. Question de tri classique. Le raccourci à mémoriser : payer fixe = vendre une obligation. Si tu tiens ça, tu ne te trompes jamais.

Vocabulaire D : *cost of carry · contango / backwardation · OTC · to clear · margin call · a swap · notional · fixed leg / floating leg*

BLOC E - Options (29-38)

29. What is an option?

"It's insurance. I pay a premium for the right, not the obligation, to buy - a call - or sell - a put - at a fixed strike."

30. Buyer vs seller?

"The buyer's loss is capped at the premium, the upside is open. The seller collects the premium and takes unlimited risk. Buyers pay to sleep; sellers get paid to take the risk."

31. In the money, at the money, out of the money?

"In the money means exercising is profitable today. At the money means the strike equals spot. Out of the money means it isn't worth exercising."

32. What is put-call parity?

"A long call plus a short put at the same strike replicates a forward on the underlying. So their prices are linked by arbitrage - otherwise you'd lock in a riskless profit."

Le chiffre : $S=100$, $K=100$, $r=4\%$, $q=2\%$, $T=0,5$, $C=6,20 \rightarrow P = 5,2149$

33. What is Black-Scholes, in one sentence?

"It prices an option by replication: you can copy the option by holding a quantity of the underlying and adjusting it continuously. If the copy is perfect, there's only one possible price."

Focus. Répondre « c'est une formule » est faible. Répondre « réplique » montre que tu as compris l'idée, et non appris la formule. C'est exactement la nuance qu'un trader écoute.

34. Name the assumptions. Which breaks first?

"Lognormal returns, constant volatility, constant rates, no transaction costs, perfect divisibility, no arbitrage, European exercise. Constant volatility breaks first - and the proof is public: the volatility smile. The market quotes a different vol for every strike, so it contradicts the model it uses."

35. What is delta?

"How much the option moves when the underlying moves. It's also the hedge ratio - how much underlying I hold to be neutral."

36. What is gamma?

"How fast delta changes. In plain terms: how quickly my hedge goes stale."

37. * You're short gamma and the market gaps. What happens?

"My delta moves against me. The market rallies, my delta goes short, so I have to buy. It sells off, I have to sell. I'm buying the highs and selling the lows on every re-hedge. I collect theta every day, but a fast market costs me more than I collect."

Focus. La meilleure question pour te démarquer. Ajoute une phrase vécue : *"I saw exactly that when I back-tested the March 2020 crash on my own pricer."* Une expérience concrète vaut dix réponses théoriques.

38. Theta and gamma - the link?

"You pay for convexity with time decay. Long gamma means I want movement and I pay theta for it. Short gamma means I collect theta and I want nothing to happen. That trade-off is the whole life of an options desk."

Vocabulaire E : *a premium · a strike · to exercise · in the money · delta hedge · to go stale · time decay · convexity · to re-hedge*

BLOC F - Volatilité (39-42)

39. Realised vs implied volatility?

"Realised is what the market did - a calculation on past data. Implied is what the market expects, backed out of option prices."

40. Is implied vol a forecast?

"It's a price, not a forecast. It's the vol level that makes the formula match the quoted price. When a trader says vol is rich, he means implied sits above what he thinks realised will be."

Focus. Dire rich et cheap plutôt qu'expensive est le marqueur le plus rapide d'un candidat qui a écouté des traders parler.

41. Why does the smile exist?

"Because real returns have fat tails - crashes happen more often than a normal distribution says. So out-of-the-money puts trade above model value: they're crash insurance. The smile is the market pricing in what the model leaves out."

42. Straddle or strangle?

"A straddle is a call and a put at the same strike - I'm betting on movement, direction doesn't matter. A strangle uses wider strikes: cheaper, but you need a bigger move to pay off."

Le chiffre : straddle 24,40 contre strangle 10,69 - le straddle coûte 2,3x plus. C'est le prix de la zone couverte.

Vocabulaire F : *implied vol · realised vol · rich / cheap · fat tails · the smile · a straddle / a strangle · vol surface*

BLOC G - Crédit et FX (43-46)

43. What is a credit spread?

"The extra yield over the government curve - the price of default risk. A 150 basis point spread on ten million is 150,000 euros a year."

44. Tightening or widening?

"Tightening means spreads narrow - the market is more confident. Widening means stress, and a flight to quality."

45. What is a CDS?

"Insurance against default. I pay an annual premium, and I'm compensated if the issuer defaults. It's also how you take a credit view without owning the bond."

46. What drives an FX forward?

"Only the interest rate differential - nothing about direction. If dollar rates are higher than euro rates, the EUR/USD forward sits above spot, exactly cancelling the carry. Otherwise there's an arbitrage. That's covered interest parity."

Le chiffre : EURUSD 1,0850, $r_{USD}=4,25\%$, $r_{EUR}=2,25\%$, 3 mois -> $F = 1,090439$, soit +54,4 pips.

Vocabulaire G : *a spread · to tighten / to widen · investment grade / high

yield · a CDS · flight to quality · a pip · carry*

BLOC H - Structuration (47-50)

47. What is a structured product?

"A packaged payoff, usually a bond plus options. A classic is capital protection: most of the money buys a zero-coupon bond that returns the principal, and the rest buys options for the upside."

Focus. Cette réponse est parfaite parce qu'elle décompose le produit au lieu de le décrire. La structuration, c'est toujours assembler des briques simples - montre que tu vois les briques.

48. What is an autocall?

"A note that redeems early if the underlying is above a barrier on an observation date. The client gets an attractive coupon, and in exchange he's short a put - he takes the downside below the barrier."

49. Why does a client buy a structured product rather than the option?

"Format and access. It comes as a single security with one price, it fits in their mandate and accounting, and the bank handles the hedging. They're buying a payoff, not a position to manage."

50. Where does the bank make its money?

"On the spread between the payoff sold and the cost of hedging it. The desk replicates the structure with vanilla instruments and keeps the difference - which is why pricing the hedge properly is the whole job."

Focus. Réponse honnête et lucide. Beaucoup de candidats disent « des frais ». Dire spread de couverture montre que tu comprends le métier.

Vocabulaire H : *a payoff · capital protection · a zero-coupon · a barrier · an autocall · to unwind · vanilla vs exotic · to replicate*

BLOC I - Ton profil (51-60)

51. Tell me about yourself.

"I'm Calvin, a final-year Master's student at SKEMA in Paris, focusing on market finance. What got me into trading was one concrete thing: I built a lab where I model a macro shock and measure the P&L of a hedged book on real data. What it taught me is that timing matters more than direction - exiting at the model peak versus holding to the stop was worth about six hundred thousand dollars on a twenty-five million book. I also did multi-asset reporting at BPCE Assurances, so I've worked with Bloomberg curves daily."

52. * What is ShockDesk?

"It's a research desk I built. I publish a dated macro forecast - say an oil shock - then I trade a multi-asset book against it and score myself afterwards. The point isn't the P&L, it's the discipline: the forecast function is point-in-time so the backtest can't see the future, the stop is set ex-ante, and the misses are published next to the hits."

Focus. Ne commence jamais par le P&L. Commencer par la méthode désamorce le scepticisme : ton interlocuteur sait que 90 % des projets étudiants sont des courbes flatteuses. Toi, tu vends l'auditabilité.

53. Why should I believe your numbers?

"Because the failures are on the same page as the wins. On the oil book, HYG and TLT both went the wrong way and they're marked as misses publicly. And getforecast only returns revisions published before the bar - so there's no look-ahead. You can check it."

54. Your alpha is negative - why should I be impressed?

"You're right, and it's on the page: the book made 1.32 percent while the S&P did 3.05. But the book isn't built to beat the index, it's a shock hedge - beta is minus 0.05. Judging it against a rising S&P is like judging insurance in a year with no fire. What I'd judge it on is eight basis points of drawdown. That said, I should benchmark it against a long-vol book, and that's my next change."

Focus. La séquence gagnante : reconnaître -> recadrer -> annoncer le correctif. Ne dis jamais « ce n'est pas grave ». On teste ta réaction sous contradiction, pas ton résultat.

55. Is this real money?

"No - it's a backtest on real market data, and I'd never present it as anything else. The forecasts are timestamped before the window so there's no look-ahead, but it hasn't traded live. That's the honest limit."

56. Why Deutsche Bank?

"Two reasons. Positioning: DB is the number one European FIC house, and the strategy is explicitly to be the global alternative to US banks - most European players are consolidating regionally. And momentum: FIC was 9.6 billion in 2025, up 13 percent, with a record last quarter driven by rates and credit."

57. Why rates rather than equities?

"Rates is where a view has to be expressed precisely. In equities you can be roughly right on direction. In rates you pick the point on the curve, the instrument, the carry. I like that the thinking is constrained."

58. Why not corporate finance, given your Master's?

"Because I found out what I actually enjoy is being marked to market every day. In corporate finance you're right in eighteen months. On a desk you're right or wrong by the close, and you have to say why. That feedback loop is what I want."

Focus. Ta formation Corporate Finance sera questionnée. Cette réponse la transforme en choix assumé plutôt qu'en défaut à excuser. Ne t'excuse jamais de ton parcours.

59. What's your weakness?

"Speaking markets in English. I read and write it fine, but I'd never practised talking about a book out loud under pressure - so I've been drilling it daily this week. It's improving, but I'm not going to pretend it's already solved."

60. Do you have any questions for me?

"Yes. I keep finding that getting the direction right matters less than getting the timing right. On a desk, when a macro view is correct but early - is that a sizing decision, a stop discipline, or do you just carry the position?"

Focus. Ne termine jamais par « non ». Cette question fait trois choses : elle prouve que tu construis quelque chose, qu'elle mesure tes erreurs, et elle pose un vrai problème de desk. Si on enchaîne par "what's the desk?" - tu pitches sur invitation, ce qui n'a rien à voir.

Les 5 phrases de secours

Situation	À dire
Répéter	"Sorry, could you repeat that?"
Gagner 3 secondes	"That's a good question - let me think."
Tu ne sais pas	"I don't know that one yet. Can you walk me through it?"
Te corriger	"Actually, let me correct myself."
Conclure	"That's how I'd approach it."

« I don't know » dit calmement est un atout. Un junior qui invente est dangereux sur un desk. Un junior qui dit « pas encore, montrez-moi » est formable - et c'est ce qu'on recrute.

Les 3 pièges de prononciation

bond /bond/ - pas « bonde » · yield /yeeld/ - pas « yeld » ·
coupon /koo-pon/. Et basis point se dit « bip ».

Les 6 réponses à connaître par cur

Si tu manques de temps, ne relis que celles-là :

16 prix/taux inversés · 24 le forward n'est pas une prévision ·
34 la vol constante casse en premier · 37 short gamma : j'achète haut,
je vends bas · 52 ShockDesk : la méthode avant le P&L · 60 ta question
finale